

The Two-Column Newsletter

Long-form content flows into two balanced columns with a divider rule between them — the same layout most printed periodicals have used since the linotype era.

CSS Multi-column 1 lets a single block split its in-flow children into N side-by-side fragmentainers. `column-count` and `column-width` jointly determine how many columns appear; `column-gap` sets the spacing between them; `column-rule` strokes a divider in each gap. Heights balance by default so neither column ends ragged when the content allows.

phpdfmk's Phase-1 implementation honours the most-asked subset of the spec: explicit `column-count`, the `columns` shorthand, the `column-rule` shorthand and its longhands, balanced flow, and an approximate equal-height balance algorithm.

Tables, inline-only blocks, and replaced elements are skipped for column generation — multi-column only applies to block

containers whose children form a block formatting context. Mid-content fragmentation (a single block splitting across columns or pages) lands with 11.2; until then a child taller than the column simply overflows its column boundary while staying whole. For typical newsletter copy that's fine.

Forced column breaks (`break-before: column`) and column-spanning elements (`column-span: all`) are Phase-2 targets — recorded in the project plan and tracked in the rendering coverage docs.

Until then the two-column layout you're reading proves the engine end-to-end: cascade resolves the shorthand, layout balances the heights, painter strokes the rule between the columns. Pure PHP, zero browser dependency.